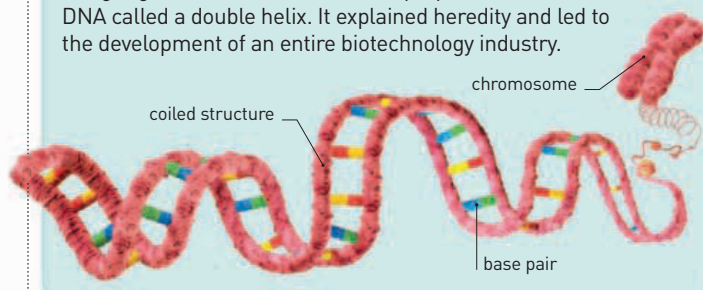




The Indochinese conflict lasted eight years, ending in 1954. This photograph shows French forces evacuating Hanoi.

DNA

A scientific breakthrough was made in 1953, when the blueprint of life, DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid), was mapped out by James Watson and Frances Crick. DNA is the hereditary material that contains the coded information needed to build and maintain all living organisms. Watson and Crick proposed a model for DNA called a double helix. It explained heredity and led to the development of an entire biotechnology industry.



War in Korea (see 1950) ended when an **armistice** was signed on July 27, but a state of suspended hostility remained. The **Republic of Korea** (South) and the **Democratic People's Republic of Korea** (North) chose not to sign the peace treaty.

Mount Everest, the world's highest mountain, was first climbed on May 29, by New Zealander **Edmund Hillary** (1919–2008) and the Nepalese Sherpa **Tenzing Norgay** (1914–86). They stayed only 15 minutes at the summit as they were low on oxygen.

A new "absurdist" play, *Waiting for Godot* by **Samuel Beckett** premiered at the Theatre de Babylone in Paris on January 5. Critics were at once divided over its merits.

FRENCH RULE IN INDOCHINA CAME TO AN END ON 21 JULY.

Laos and **Cambodia** became independent, while Vietnam was divided into **North Vietnam**, with a communist government, and **South Vietnam**. In all three noncommunist states, communist guerrilla movements sprang up.

Senator **Joseph McCarthy** intensified his campaign to root out communists (see 1950). He set his sights on the US army and made unsubstantiated allegations against them. This led to his being censored by the Senate on December 2. Public support dwindled, and McCarthy's reign of fear ended.

A **vaccine for polio** was tested in a huge field trial in the US, in April. The trials were successful, and a **nationwide vaccination** scheme was started the following year.

ISRAELI FORCES CONDUCTED A SURPRISE RAID on the Egyptian-held **Gaza Strip** in February. The raid was the largest of its kind against Arab forces since the end of the First Arab–Israeli War in 1949 (see 1956).

Under its **apartheid** legislation, the South African government forcibly evicted 60,000 black people from **Sophiatown**, in February, to make it a white-only suburb. The **African National Congress** (ANC), an antiapartheid organization, responded with a day of prayer.

The Friendship, Cooperation and Mutual Assistance Treaty, known as the **Warsaw Pact**, was signed on May 14. The treaty set up a military alliance of communist states to **counter NATO** in the West.

The **Soviet Union** ended its occupation of **Austria**, which had been ongoing since the end of World War II, on condition that

Eastern alliance

The Warsaw Pact united the Eastern Bloc in a similar alliance to NATO. The signatories were Albania, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia, East Germany, Hungary, Poland, and the USSR.



ROSA PARKS (1913–2005)

Rosa Parks made history when she refused to give up her seat on a bus for a white man. Her arrest mobilized a boycott of the bus system, which ended segregation on Montgomery's buses. The boycott also brought international attention to the civil rights cause. Parks remained committed to her cause, and was a symbol of the struggle for civil rights until her death in 2005, aged 92.



Austria remained neutral. The **Austrian State Treaty** was signed on May 15, reestablishing Austria as an independent sovereign state. It joined the UN the same year.

Juan Perón's position as president of Argentina was weakened by his wife's death and a quarrel with the Roman Catholic Church. He was **overthrown** in a coup on September 19, and exiled to Paraguay.

There was a turning point in the US **Civil Rights movement** on

December 1, when **Rosa Parks** broke Alabama race laws by refusing to move to the back of a bus. Thousands boycotted the bus company in protest.

In the West, by the mid-1950s, **teenagers** stood out as a distinct group with interests, musical tastes, and their own fashions. This led to disapproval from adults who feared **juvenile delinquency**. New slang was condemned, dances were closed, and some institutions banned the wearing of jeans.

June 19 Julius and Ethel Rosenberg executed for espionage

July 27 End of the Korean War (began 1950)

April 18 Colonel Nasser becomes Egyptian prime minister

July 19 Elvis Presley releases his first single

December 2 Senator Joseph McCarthy censured by US Senate

July 21 Indochina War ends

February 10 60,000 black people removed from Sophiatown, South Africa, as part of apartheid laws

March 11 Death of Alexander Fleming, British biologist famous for discovering penicillin (b. 1881)

May 14 Warsaw Pact founded

April 18 Death of German physicist Albert Einstein (b. 1879)

May 20 Catholic church disestablished in Argentina

August 12 Death of German novelist Thomas Mann (b. 1875)

September 18 Britain admits that Guy Burgess and Donald Maclean were Soviet spies

September 30 Death of teen heartthrob and actor James Dean (b. 1931)

September 19 General Juan Perón of Argentina overthrown

November 2 Ben-Gurion forms a government in Israel

October 26 South Vietnam declared a republic

November 28 State of emergency declared in Cyprus after anti-British riots